Where Campaigns Travelled, and Where They Did Not

Eight months of one campaign's travel log, and the half of America that never appears in it

84-355 Democracy's Data

August 2026

Between 13 March and 04 November 2024, five people made 377 public campaign appearances in the United States: the two presidential nominees, their running mates, and the president who withdrew in July. 25 of the 51 jurisdictions that cast electoral votes received none of them. Not a rally, not a fundraiser, not a fifteen-minute stop at a diner. In half the country, across eight months, nobody came.

A presidential campaign has more money than it can spend well, more staff than it can supervise and more advice than it can use. It has exactly one resource that cannot be manufactured: **the candidate's own time.** There are a fixed number of days, and the candidate can be in one place on each of them. The travel schedule is therefore a ranked list of the campaign's own judgments about where the election will be decided, compiled by the people with the best polling in the country and revised daily. It is a strategy document that a campaign publishes by executing it.

Start with what one line of it is.

Date	City	State	Candidate	Event type
2024-03-13	Milwaukee	Wisconsin	Biden	Campaign
2024-09-13	Las Vegas	Nevada	Trump	Campaign
2024-11-01	Dearborn	Michigan	Trump	Campaign

One row is **one public appearance, by one person, in one city, on one day.** Not a day of campaigning, not a state visit, not an advertising buy — an event.

That definition is doing more work than it looks. A rally of twenty thousand and a fifteen-minute stop at a diner are both exactly one row, and nothing in this file distinguishes them. Every count below is a count of *occasions*.

01 How much of a campaign this is

Quantity	Value
Campaign stops logged	377
People tracked	5

Quantity	Value
First stop	13 March 2024
Last stop	04 November 2024
States with at least one stop	26
Distinct cities	177
Source	AP campaign trail tracker, version 54

Note who compiled this. Campaign-finance data exists because federal law compels its filing. Nothing compelled any of this. A news organization watched the campaigns and wrote down where they went, and the file exists at the Associated Press's discretion. That is why it carries a version number, and why the version number turns out to matter.

Nothing in the Constitution says a presidential campaign should visit some places and not others. The concentration comes from one rule, adopted state by state and written nowhere in federal law: **the winner of a state takes all of its electoral votes.** Under that rule a vote is worth campaigning for only if it might change which candidate crosses 270, which means only where the outcome is in doubt.

Whether any of that matters depends on whether attention does anything, and it does. **Enos and Fowler (2018)** compared targeted and untargeted states in 2012. They estimated that the presidential campaigns raised turnout in heavily targeted states by **about 7 to 8 percentage points**, mostly through traditional ground campaigning. Being campaigned in is not a symbolic good. People in battleground states are mobilized, informed and argued with; people elsewhere are left to watch.

02 The only witness there is

The travel log is an Associated Press interactive, *Tracking the 2024 presidential campaign trail*, published at an embed address that carries a version number. The table above is its whole extent: 377 appearances by 5 people over eight months. It is a wire cooperative's byproduct. Reporters covering a beat wrote down where the candidates were, and somebody decided the accumulation was worth publishing. There is no methodology note, no codebook, no correction log, and nobody signed it.

It was never published as data, either. What can be fetched is the CSV that feeds the interactive graphic, the file the page loads in order to draw itself. It is not a dataset with a landing page and a citation. That is where the version number in the address comes from. It means the download is one easy line of code that will stop working, with no announcement, on the day the graphic is retired.

That is a thinner record than anything in the campaign-finance chapters, and it is still the best evidence there is, because the alternative is none. No agency collects candidate itineraries. A campaign's internal schedule is disclosed to nobody, and the FEC file records what a campaign spent without recording where the candidate stood while spending it. The question here has no official record and is never going to acquire one: where did the people with the best polling in the country believe the election would be decided? A newsroom's log is not a second-best substitute for a filing. It is the only witness.

What that costs is a definition nobody published. Someone at AP decided what counts as a public campaign appearance, and the decision is invisible from here. A fundraiser in a private home, a local television interview, an official White House event that is also a campaign event: each is in or out by a judgment made off the page. The very first row of this file is an infrastructure announcement, which the notes column says in as many words. Coverage is unlikely to be even either, since the principals were watched more closely than their running mates and a wire service's attention is not spread uniformly over fifty states. None of that is falsifiable from inside the file, which is a different position from a filing that can be checked against the document it summarizes.

One more thing belongs here rather than in the source, because it is a property of the build. **A state that received no attention is not a row in this file.** The tracker records events, and a place with no events leaves nothing to record. The 25 jurisdictions that got no stop enter this chapter only because the state results are kept as a separate table and joined back to the visits. That join keeps every state and fills the missing counts with zero.

The opening claim of this chapter is in that sense manufactured by a join. The silence had to be built, because absence does not write itself down. The file's other instability, that it went on changing after it had been cited, gets a section of its own further on and is worth waiting for.

03 A file built to draw a graphic

The capture is kept exactly as it arrived. Here is its first record, every column of it, with a star against the ones this chapter keeps.

Column as it arrives	What it holds	Value in record 1	This chapter
date	the date of the event	3/13/24	kept
city	the city it was held in	Milwaukee	kept
county	the county	Milwaukee	kept
state	the state, spelled out	Wisconsin	kept
postal	the state's two-letter code — the same fact again	WI	kept
lat	latitude	43.0642	kept
long	longitude	-87.9673	kept
fips	county FIPS code	55079	kept
candidate	who appeared	Biden	kept
event-type	what kind of event it was	Campaign	kept
notes	free text about the event	Roadway infrastructre improvements event	kept
biden-total-visits-city	tooltip: Biden's running total for this city	5	—
biden-total-visits-county	tooltip: his running total for the county	7	—
biden-total-visits-state	tooltip: his running total for the state	29	—

Column as it arrives	What it holds	Value in record 1	This chapter
trump-total-visits-city	tooltip: Trump's running total for this city	4	—
trump-total-visits-county	tooltip: his running total for the county	4	—
trump-total-visits-state	tooltip: his running total for the state	21	—
total-state-visits	tooltip: both candidates, this state	50	—
total-county-visits	tooltip: both candidates, this county	11	—
total-city-visits	tooltip: both candidates, this city	9	—
biden-date	tooltip: date formatted for display	11/4/24	—
trump-date	tooltip: date formatted for display	11/1/24	—
city-visits-status	tooltip: text describing the city's visit count	Both	—
county-text	tooltip: the county sentence shown to a reader	Milwaukee County	—
reg-voters	tooltip: registered voters in the county	489,950	—
reg-voters-as-of-date	tooltip: the date that count was taken	August 13	—

That is record 1 of 377, all 26 columns of it.

26 columns arrive and 11 are kept, and the 15 that go are the most interesting thing in the file. `biden-total-visits-city`, `total-state-visits`, `county-text`, `reg-voters`: none of those is a fact about the event on this row. They are the contents of the tooltip that appears when a reader hovers over a dot on AP's map. This is not a dataset with a graphic attached. It is a graphic's payload, and the rows are events only incidentally.

That has consequences a codebook would have warned about. The counts in those columns are cumulative over the whole campaign, so the same total is repeated on every row of the same city and would be badly wrong if anyone summed the column. `reg-voters` arrives as the text 489,950, quoted, with a thousands separator inside it, which is a number formatted for a reader rather than a number. `reg-voters-as-of-date` is August 13 with no year in it. And the date the chapter runs on arrives as 3/13/24, which sorts as text into an order no calendar recognizes.

The kept version is eleven columns and one event per row:

Date	City	State	Candidate	Event type	Notes
2024-03-13	Milwaukee	Wisconsin	Biden	Campaign	Roadway infrastructre improvements…
2024-03-14	Saginaw	Michigan	Biden	Campaign	Meet with campaign workers and sup…

Three judgments, and the third is the one that makes the chapter.

Take the columns that describe the row, and drop the ones that describe the page. Everything cumulative goes, and it goes because it is precomputed. Any total this chapter wants is recomputed from the events themselves, which is slower and is the only way the total can be checked.

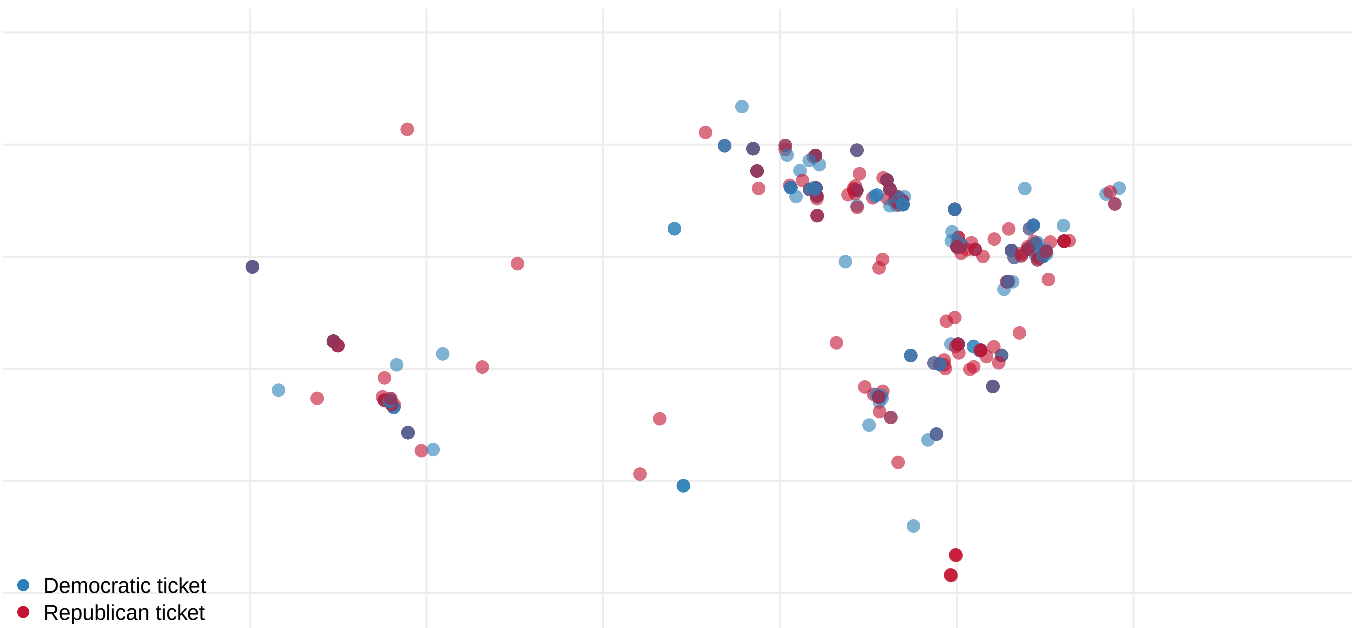
Parse the date, and refuse to continue if any of them fails. 3/13/24 becomes 2024-03-13. Two-digit years are ambiguous by construction, and the build stops outright if a single row fails to convert rather than letting one silent `NA` fall out of a chart.

Manufacture the zeros. This is the important one. AP's file records events, so a state where nothing happened contributes no row. Counted straight, the file has 26 states in it and the United States has 51 jurisdictions with electoral votes. The 25 places nobody went exist in this chapter only because the build writes a separate file of state results. The setup joins the two, keeps every state whether or not it matched, and fills the empty side with zero rather than with `NA`.

Absence does not write itself down. The central claim of this chapter is a fact about rows that had to be created, from a second source, in order to be counted at all.

04 Where they went

State	Electoral votes	Margin (pts)	Stops
Pennsylvania	19	1.71	80
Michigan	15	1.42	63
Wisconsin	10	0.86	50
North Carolina	16	3.21	45
Arizona	11	5.50	27
Georgia	16	2.20	26



Quantity	Value
Top seven states' share of all stops	83.8%

Quantity	Value
Top seven states' share of the electoral college	17.3%
Stops in states decided by under 5 points	78.5%

Figure 1. Every logged stop of the 2024 campaign, placed where it happened. One mark per appearance, 377 in all, by five people over eight months. The clustering is not an artifact of population: the empty regions include some of the largest cities in the country.

Seven states holding 17.3% of the electoral college absorbed 83.8% of the campaign.

The empty half of that map is the finding. Pennsylvania alone took 80 stops across 36 different towns — a stop somewhere in one state every 3.0 days, for eight months.

05 Where they did not go

That table was built by counting rows in the visit file. A state that never appears in the file has no row to count, and so does not appear in the answer either. To see the states that got nothing, the counting has to start from a list of all the states and attach the visits to it, rather than the other way round.

Quantity	Value
States and DC in the results file	51
With at least one stop	26
With none	25
Electoral votes held by the zero-stop states	146
Their share of the electoral college	27.1%

25 of 51 jurisdictions, half the country, received not one stop from any of the five people on the two tickets, in eight months. Between them they hold 146 electoral votes, 27.1% of the total.

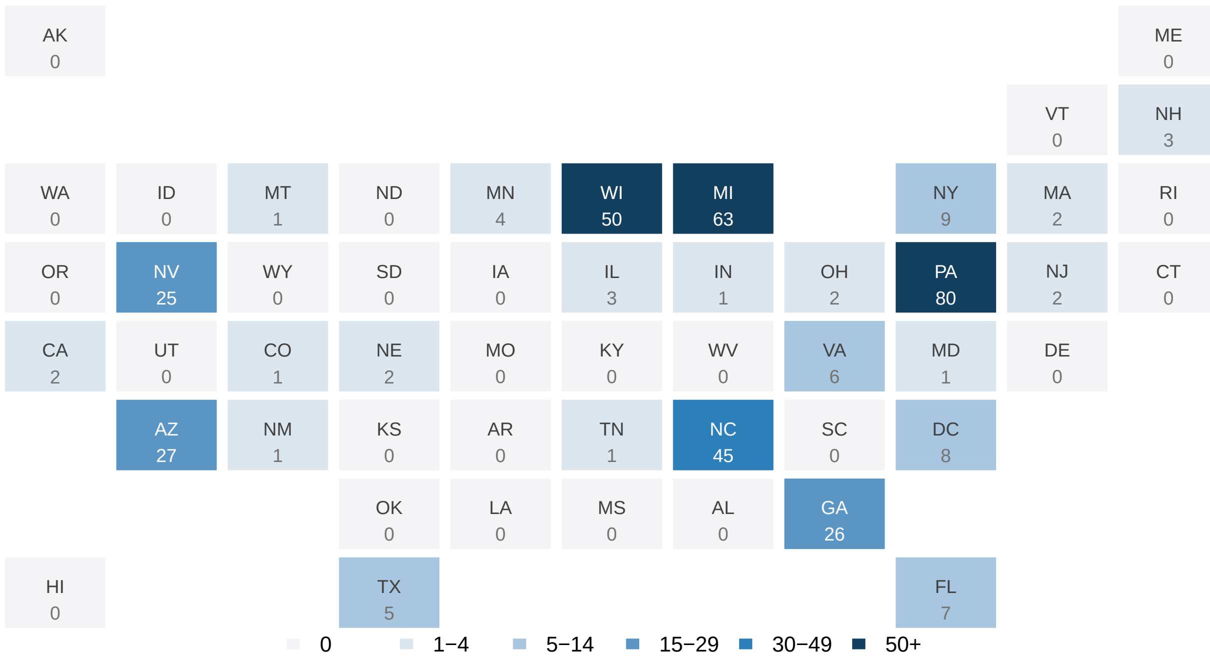


Figure 2. The country as a grid, shaded by how many stops each state received. One tile per jurisdiction, positioned roughly where the state belongs. The 25 blank tiles are the states nobody visited; between them they hold 146 electoral votes, 27.1% of the total.

The cartogram shows *which* states were skipped. It cannot show what they were owed, because every tile is the same size whatever the state's electoral weight. Put the two quantities on the same axes and the disproportion becomes a single shape. Figure 3 orders all 51 jurisdictions from least to most attention per electoral vote, then walks along them accumulating both their electoral votes and their campaign stops.

> **Before you turn to that figure, put a number to it.** Walk up that ordering until you have half the electoral college in hand — the 25 states that got nothing, which between them hold 27.1% of the college, and then however many lightly-visited states it takes to reach fifty. **What share of the 377 stops did that bottom half of the country receive?** Write down a percentage now, while the only thing you have to go on is the map.

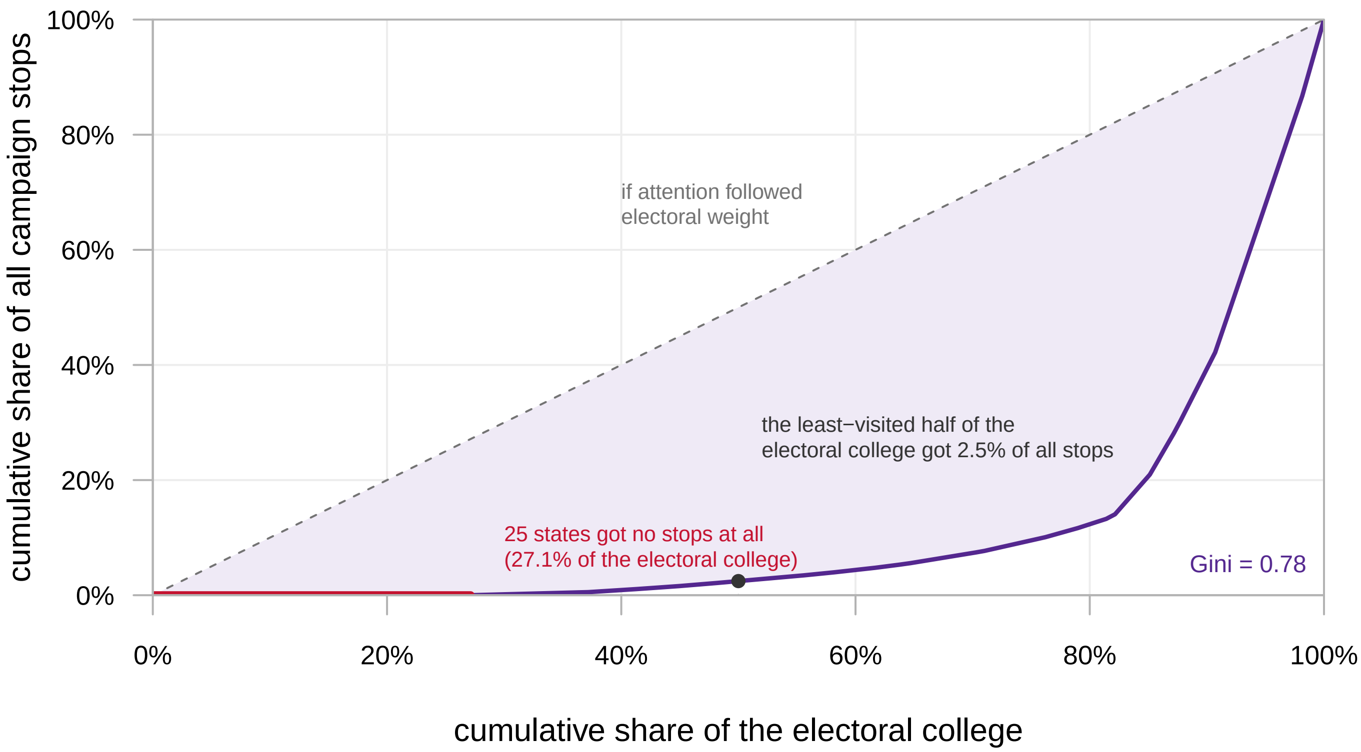


Figure 3. How the campaign's time was distributed across the electoral college. Each point is one state, added in order of how much attention it got per electoral vote. The horizontal axis is the running share of electoral votes, and the vertical axis the running share of stops. The dashed diagonal is the country a campaign would visit if it weighted every electoral vote equally. The red segment along the bottom is the 25 states that received nothing: 27.1% of the electoral college and none of the campaign. The Gini coefficient of the curve is 0.78.

The least-visited half of the electoral college received 2.5% of all campaign stops. Most people guess somewhere in the teens, reasoning that the zero-stop bloc is only 27.1% of the college and that the states sitting just above it must have picked up a respectable remainder. They did not: the whole bottom half of the country, weighted the way the Constitution weights it, is worth about 9 of the 377 stops. The Gini coefficient of that curve is 0.78 — a level of concentration that would be reported as extreme if the quantity being divided were income rather than a candidate's time.

This is where most analyses of this kind go wrong, and it comes down to one word. The join behind these figures keeps every state whether or not it matched a visit (`all.x = TRUE`). The default behavior keeps only the states appearing in both files. Run the default and the 25 blank tiles vanish silently: no warning, no error, a perfectly clean table describing a country that does not exist.

06 Attention per unit of electoral weight

State	Electoral votes	Margin (pts)	Stops	Stops per electoral vote
Wisconsin	10	0.86	50	5.00

State	Electoral votes	Margin (pts)	Stops	Stops per electoral vote
Pennsylvania	19	1.71	80	4.21
Nevada	6	3.10	25	4.17
Texas	40	13.68	5	0.12
California	54	20.14	2	0.04

Nevada has 6 electoral votes to California's 54, and received 25 stops to California's 2. Per electoral vote, Nevada got about **113 times** the attention California did. Texas, the second-largest prize in the country, received 5.

07 The two obvious explanations, and what happens to them

Candidates go where the votes are. That is the first thing anyone would guess, and it is testable in one line.

Quantity	Value
Correlation, stops and electoral votes (all 51)	0.21
Three largest states' electoral votes	124
Their combined stops	14

0.21. Essentially nothing. California, Texas and Florida hold 124 electoral votes between them and received 14 stops in total — fewer than any one of the seven most-visited states, the smallest of which got 25.

Size is not the answer. The natural second guess is closeness.

Quantity	Value
Correlation, stops and margin of victory (all 51)	-0.41
States decided by under 5 points	8
Of those, how many got fewer than 5 stops	2

-0.41 — better, and in the right direction: the closer the state, the more stops. But it is a moderate correlation, not a mechanism, and the exceptions are conspicuous.

State	Electoral votes	Margin (pts)	Stops
New Hampshire	4	2.78	3
Minnesota	10	4.24	4
Nevada	6	3.10	25
Georgia	16	2.20	26

State	Electoral votes	Margin (pts)	Stops
North Carolina	16	3.21	45
Wisconsin	10	0.86	50
Michigan	15	1.42	63
Pennsylvania	19	1.71	80

New Hampshire was decided by 2.78 points and got 3 stops; Minnesota, decided by 4.24, got 4. Both were close and both were left alone.

So neither variable works. Size explains almost nothing, and closeness explains something but not much. The two most obvious accounts of campaign strategy have both failed a simple test, on a file that ought to be the ideal case for them.

08 Neither variable works, and both do

Ask the size question again, but only of the close states. Then ask the closeness question again, but only of the large states.

Question	Correlation
Among all 51 jurisdictions: do stops track size?	0.21
Among all 51: do stops track closeness?	-0.41
Among the 8 states within 5 points: do stops track size?	0.74
Among the 10 largest states: do stops track closeness?	-0.83

Among the 8 states decided by under five points, size and stops correlate at 0.74. Among the ten largest states, closeness and stops correlate at -0.83.

Marginally, each variable is nearly useless. Conditionally, each is powerful. That is the signature of an **interaction**: the effect of one variable depends on the value of the other, and averaging over the other destroys it.

Build the product directly: electoral votes multiplied by whether the state was within five points, an index with no tuning in it. Then correlate that with stops:

Measure	Correlation with stops
Electoral votes alone	0.21
Margin alone	-0.41
Electoral votes x (within 5 points)	0.87

0.87, using no information that was not already in the two failed variables.

A campaign is not asking "where are the voters?" and it is not asking "where is it close?" It is asking one question that multiplies the two: *where might a day of my time change who wins?* A large safe state fails that test. A tiny close state passes it barely. A large close state is worth 80 visits.

This is the winner-take-all rule expressed as a travel schedule, and Figure 4 is what it looks like when every jurisdiction is plotted at once.

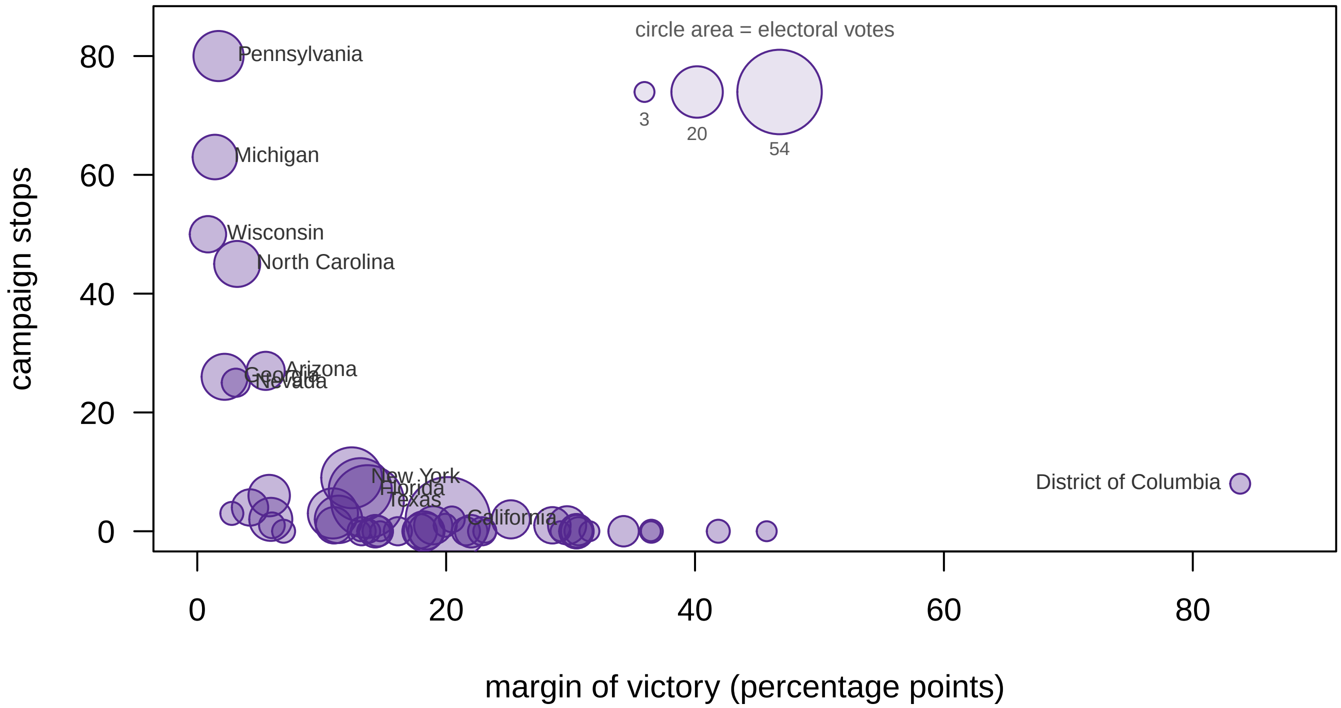


Figure 4. Stops against the prize a state represented. One point per jurisdiction: electoral votes on one axis, the campaign's stops on the other, with the states decided by under five points distinguished from the rest. Neither size nor closeness orders this picture on its own; their product correlates with stops at 0.87.

09 Two rows that do not mean what the column says

Look at the far right of that plot. One jurisdiction was decided by 83.81 points and still logged 8 stops.

Date	Candidate	What the event was
2024-05-25	Trump	Remarks at the Libertarian National Convention
2024-06-11	Biden	Speaks at Everytown's Gun Sense University at the Washington Hilton
2024-06-22	Trump	Remarks at the Faith and Freedom convention
2024-07-10	Biden	Meets union members at AFL-CIO

Nobody was campaigning in Washington for Washington's 3 electoral votes. They were speaking to national conventions of interest groups, in the city where the studios, the donors and the press corps already are. For two of the five people in this file, so is the office. The audience was not in the room, and it was not in the District.

The row satisfies every filter you would write. It does not belong to the question you are asking. And it is not harmless:

Sample	Correlation, stops and margin
All 51 jurisdictions	-0.41
The 50 states, DC removed	-0.53

Removing one row of 51 moves the correlation from -0.41 to -0.53. One misclassified case was suppressing about a quarter of the relationship.

Now the opposite error. Nebraska is a safe state, decided by 20.46 points, so the index above predicts nothing there. It got 2 stops:

Date	City	Candidate
2024-08-17	Omaha	Walz
2024-10-19	Omaha	Walz

Both in Omaha, because **Nebraska does not award its electoral votes winner-take-all.** One goes to the winner of the Omaha-centered congressional district, and that district was genuinely in play. The results file has one row per state and no row for a district, so the prize the campaign was chasing is not represented anywhere in the data.

DC is a row that satisfies the filter and does not belong to the question. Nebraska is a prize that belongs to the question and has no row. Both are the same failure: the unit of the file is not the unit of the thing being contested.

10 The source kept moving after it was cited

The AP tracker lives at a URL carrying a **version number**, and AP went on publishing new versions after the election. The figures above were originally built against version 50 and are now built against version 54. Both are still served, so the two can be put side by side.

AP version	Stops	Last event	States	Stops dated on or before 01 Nov
50	324	2024-11-01	25	324
54	377	2024-11-04	26	339

Two different things happened, and only one of them is obvious.

The tracker gained the ending. Version 50 stops on 01 November, four days before the election. Version 54 runs to 04 November and adds 38 stops in those final days. That is 10.1% of the entire eight-month campaign packed into three days. It is exactly the closing rush you would expect, and exactly what the older file could not show.

The tracker also rewrote the part it had already covered. Both versions claim everything up to 01 November. For that window the old capture has 324 stops and the new one has 339. **15 events were added to a period the file already claimed to describe.** One of them put a state on the map that had none before. New Mexico went from zero stops to 1, which moves a tile on the cartogram and changes the count of skipped states by one.

A public dataset with no statutory deadline has no moment at which it is finished. The census closes; a campaign-finance filing has a due date and an amendment history; this has neither. It is complete when a newsroom stops updating it, and nothing announces that day. **A citation to this source without a version number does not identify what was read** — which is why one version is pinned here, both are fetched, and the comparison is kept in `ap_snapshots.csv`.

11 Two more edges, and the calendar that shows them

Quantity	Value
Last stop logged	04 November 2024
Election day	05 November 2024
Biden's last stop, and Harris's first	16 July / 23 July
Democratic ticket stops, Republican ticket stops	188 / 189

It still ends the day before the election, so every count remains a floor — much closer to the truth than version 50 allowed, and still short.

The candidate changed mid-file. Biden's last logged stop and Harris's first are 7 days apart in July, so any comparison of "the Democrat" to "the Republican" over time compares a continuous campaign to a broken one. As whole tickets the two sides are nearly matched, 188 to 189. That surprises people who expect one side to have obviously more.

Every figure so far has thrown the `date` column away. Put it back and both of those edges, and the closing surge the new version added, become visible at once.

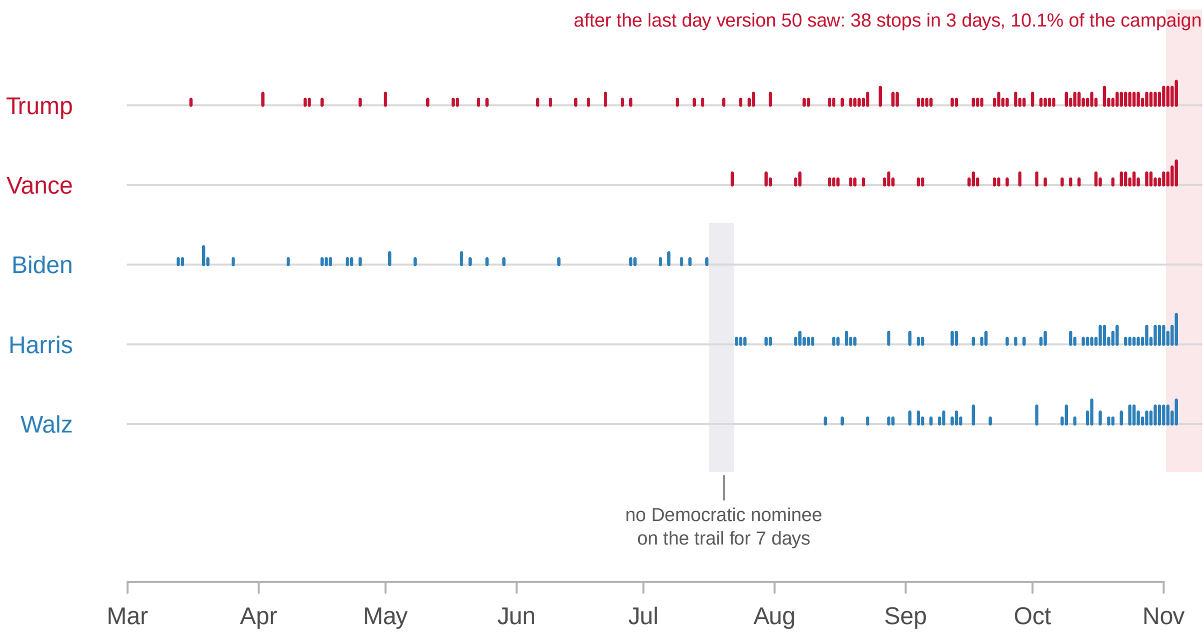


Figure 5. The whole campaign as a calendar. One lane per person, one tick per logged stop, taller where somebody made several appearances in a day; red is the Republican ticket and blue the Democratic. The gray band is the week between Biden's last stop and

Harris's first. The pink band at the right is the final 38 stops, 10.1% of the entire eight-month campaign, which version 50 never saw.

The lanes make three claims visible at once. **Biden's lane simply stops** in July and Harris's starts a week later, so no continuous "Democratic campaign" exists to compare against Trump's. **Walz has no lane at all before 13 August,** so his 73 stops are 19.4% of the file compressed into its last third. And **every lane thickens into the pink band**: 38 of 377 stops, 10.1% of the whole campaign, fall in the last three days — the part version 50 was missing.

12 Where the presidency was actually contested

The 2024 presidential campaign was conducted in seven states. They took 83.8% of all stops and hold 17.3% of the electoral college, while 25 states saw nobody at all.

The mechanism is not a slogan. Neither size nor closeness predicts attention on its own, at 0.21 and -0.41; their product does, at 0.87. Campaigns behave as though they are maximizing the chance that a day of the candidate's time changes an outcome, which is exactly what winner-take-all rewards.

It follows that **the Electoral College does not reward smallness.** Nevada and New Hampshire are small and were visited; Wyoming, Vermont, the Dakotas, Delaware and Alaska are small and were not. The system rewards closeness, and a few small states happen to be close.

None of it says anything about effort, money or audience, since an arena and a diner are one row each. Nor about what turnout or votes any of this produced. Nothing here measures a consequence. And no number from this file can be cited without saying which version of it was read.

13 Whether the concentration is a defect

The standard defense of the Electoral College is that it protects small states. This data neither supports that defense nor quite refutes it. It replaces it with a sharper claim. The system rewards *competitiveness*, not size in either direction. A small safe state is the most ignored place in America, and a small close state is the most courted. Which one a given state is has nothing to do with the Electoral College, and everything to do with how its voters happen to be divided in a particular cycle.

The serious reply is that the counterfactual is not equality. Under a national popular vote attention would be reallocated, not spread out: campaigns would go where votes are cheap to move in bulk. Whether that concentrates attention more or less than the present arrangement is an empirical question, and 377 rows from one election cannot answer it.

A second dispute is about what a visit is for. Chen and Reeves (2011) studied county-level appearances in 2008 and found the two tickets following different logics. McCain-Palin concentrated on counties where the previous Republican ticket had done well, which is a base strategy. Obama-Biden went to fast-growing counties on the edges of metropolitan areas. If mobilization and persuasion imply different maps, then "attention" is not one quantity, and a state-level count of stops averages over the distinction. Figure 1 is at the right level of detail to test that; this chapter does not test it.

A third is about consequences for citizens rather than candidates. Gimpel, Kaufmann and Pearson-Merkowitz (2007) compared battleground and "blackout" states and found differences in political engagement between them. On that account Figure 2 describes not only where campaigns go but where political life is more intense. That makes the 25 blank tiles a claim about the quality of democratic life, rather than about travel budgets.

14 What a travel log can testify to

The strengths are real. This is a near-complete record of public appearances by both tickets, geocoded and dated. Both sides were watched by the same observer applying the same rule, which makes a ticket-to-ticket comparison mean something, in a way that comparisons across differently sourced files usually do not.

The weaknesses begin with what kind of document it is. **It is a news organization's log, not a legal filing.** Nobody can be penalized for an omission, and coverage of the running mates is probably less complete than coverage of the principals. It is versioned, and the version moved: 324 stops became 377, 15 of them backfilled into a window the earlier file already claimed to cover, and nothing guarantees version 54 is the last. It ends on 04 November, the day before the election, so every count in this chapter is a floor.

Then there are the limits of the unit. **An event is an event**: no crowd size, no time spent, no money, which is the single largest weakness of the file. 25 states have no rows in it at all, so any analysis beginning from the visit file rather than from a list of states will never see them. The five-point cut that defines a close state is a convention rather than a fact about the world. The pattern survives other thresholds, but the exact correlations move.

And 0.21 is a correlation computed on a badly lopsided variable. The rank correlation between size and stops is 0.61, appreciably larger. So "size does not matter" is too strong, and *size alone does not order the map* is right. The unit is the state, which is the wrong unit for Maine and Nebraska and for the cities that Figure 1 shows and everything after it throws away. And it is one election, in which only 13 states finished within ten points; nothing here establishes that 2024 was typical.

Three questions stay open. Whether attention caused anything in this cycle: Enos and Fowler found large turnout effects in 2012, and this file has no turnout column. What a national popular vote would actually look like on the ground, as opposed to in the abstract. And whether the two tickets were running the same play at all, which needs county-level detail rather than state counts.

The travel log is a strategy document that nobody wrote down as a strategy. Read as one, it says that the presidency of a country of three hundred and forty million people was contested in seven states. The rule producing that result is not in the Constitution. It is in fifty separate statutes, each of which could be amended by the legislature that passed it.

15 Sources

Data

- Associated Press, "Tracking the 2024 presidential campaign trail," version 54. https://interactives.ap.org/embeds/ziEfd/54/ — public campaign appearances by both tickets, 13 March to 04 November 2024. Version 50, against which the earlier release of this lab was built, is retained for comparison in `ap_snapshots.csv`.
- State-level 2024 presidential returns, the same file used in Weeks 1 and 2.
- The state-name join is checked, and the two published versions of the tracker are compared, rather than either being taken on trust.

The data itself

Every figure above is drawn from these tables. They are plain CSV, they open in a spreadsheet, and they are yours to take further.

`ap_snapshots.csv`, `campaign_visits_2024.csv`, `pres2024_states.csv`

Your turn

None of these is answered above, and every one can be answered from the tables you just opened.

- `campaign_visits_2024.csv` has a state on every event. Count events per state, then join `pres2024_states.csv` and compare against `ev` and `margin`. How much of the country got no visit at all?
- Compute visits per electoral vote for the states that were visited. Which states got more attention than their weight, and which got less?
- `ap_snapshots.csv` records two versions of the same file, with different row counts and a different `last_event`. Work out what the earlier version was missing. What would you have published from it?
- Group the events by `event_type` and by candidate. Do the two campaigns travel the same way?

Academic literature

- Chen, L. J. and Reeves, A. (2011). "Turning Out the Base or Appealing to the Periphery? An Analysis of County-Level Candidate Appearances in the 2008 Presidential Campaign." *American Politics Research* 39(3): 534–556.
- Enos, R. D. and Fowler, A. (2018). "Aggregate Effects of Large-Scale Campaigns on Voter Turnout." *Political Science Research and Methods* 6(4): 733–751.
- Gimpel, J. G., Kaufmann, K. M. and Pearson-Merkowitz, S. (2007). "Battleground States versus Blackout States: The Behavioral Implications of Modern Presidential Campaigns." *The Journal of Politics* 69(3): 786–797.

Further reading

- Shaw, D. R. (1999). "The Effect of TV Ads and Candidate Appearances on Statewide Presidential Votes, 1988–96." *American Political Science Review* 93(2): 345–361.
- Shaw, D. R. (2006). *The Race to 270: The Electoral College and the Campaign Strategies of 2000 and 2004.* University of Chicago Press.

REBUILD THIS DATA YOURSELF, WITH AN AI ASSISTANT

I want to rebuild a public dataset from its original source, without any starting files. Please do the following and show your work.

THE SOURCE. Associated Press, ”Tracking the 2024 presidential campaign trail” — the dataset behind the AP’s interactive tracker, served plainly with no account or key:

https://interactives.ap.org/embeds/ziEfd/54/dataset.csv

Each row is one campaign stop by a 2024 presidential or vice presidential candidate: date, city, county, state, coordinates, candidate, and type of event. It is a news organisation’s log, not a government filing — a rally of twenty thousand and a diner stop are one row each.

HOW TO FETCH IT. The 54 in that address is a version number, and THE VERSION NUMBER IS PART OF THE CITATION. The AP kept publishing new versions after the election. Version 50 stops on 1 November 2024 — four days short, final weekend missing — while version 54 runs through 4 November and also quietly adds events to days version 50 already claimed to cover. Both were still being served when this book fetched them, so fetch both: the same address with /50/ and with /54/.

WHAT TO BUILD.

1. A tidy table of the stops in version 54, one row per event, sorted by date.

2. A comparison of the two versions: how many rows each has, the date of its last event, and — for the window BOTH claim to cover, up to 1 November — how many events each reports there.

CHECK YOUR WORK. The copies this book used were fetched in August 2026. If your rebuild matches them, you should find:

- 377 stops in version 54, ending 4 November 2024
- 324 stops in version 50, ending 1 November 2024
- in the shared window, version 54 reports 339 events — fifteen were backfilled into days the older version had already covered

If either address now answers differently, the tracker moved again; that is the source revising itself, not an error in your rebuild.